

WHAT TIPS A TROUBLED TEEN OVER THE EDGE

43% EXAMINATION FEAR

40% SIBLING RIVALRY

36% ISSUES AT SCHOOL

33% WARRING PARENTS

20% FEAR OF PUNISHMENT

17% DEATH OF A LOVED ONE

17% DISTRESSED PARENTS

Source: Child & Adolescent Psychiatry Clinic, AIIMS

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Being a teenager has never been easy. But in the new millennium, amidst unprecedented prosperity, growing up seems to have become more trying than ever for Indian teens. While self-inflicted deaths among adolescents in the West are levelling off, India is topping the world in teen suicides. If drugs, alcohol and firearms are the favourite routes to self-destruction in the West, it's exam stress and inability to cope with disappointments here. Every 90 minutes a teenager tries to commit suicide in India. Many of these attempts are half-hearted cries for attention, help and love. But every six hours, one succeeds.

More adolescents die of suicide than AIDS, cancer, heart disease, obesity, birth defects and lung disease. In 2006-07 5,857 students took their own life, which works out to a stunning 16 suicides a day, says the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB). While the global teen suicide rate is 14.5 per 100,000, a 2004 study by the Christian

Medical College (CMC), Vellore, reported 148 for girls and 58 for boys in India. If globally, suicide is the fourth leading cause of teen deaths, in India it is at number one in some pockets and is the third largest killer all across. Over 150 students ended their lives across the country last month.

The grim epithet to

their tormented lives is the suicide note. Sometimes they express an inability to cope with pressure, as in the case of a Delhi student who hanged himself from a ceiling fan by his mother's sari. "Goodbye," he wrote. "I can't take the pressure any longer. I love my family and I hope they will understand." Ever so often there is helplessness: "I am not doing well in exams," wrote a girl from Chandigarh to her parents before she took her life, "I can't even manage my own affairs. I've frittered away my college fees on trivia. No one's responsible for my death." At times, there's self-reproach. "I couldn't make it because of the exam backlog that I need to clear," jotted down a student of IIT-Powai while his friends made merry at a campus fest, adding, "But I want to thank my professors and I am sorry for doing this." Often there is anger: "I'll come back as a ghost to haunt my teachers."

"There's not one symptom that's going to leap out to a parent. Rather a cluster of changes in behaviour and personality."

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